

ÉLÉONORE BESSE

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PROFILE

Curator, art historian and cultural project manager specialising in international modern and contemporary art, with experience in cultural research, documentary research, exhibition development, project coordination, institutional partnerships and fundraising across France, the UK and the US. Bilingual French-English, with an academic background from the University of Oxford and University of Edinburgh. Strong experience researching complex cultural subjects, verifying and synthesising information, coordinating multiple stakeholders and translating specialist content into clear strategic and public-facing documents.

SELECTED STRENGTHS

- Cultural and art-historical research; documentary, bibliographical and visual research
- Artwork research, checklists, source verification and exhibition documentation
- Project coordination from concept and research through to production and delivery
- Strategic notes, presentations, meeting documentation and bilingual written communication
- Institutional partnerships and international stakeholder liaison
- Fundraising, sponsorship development and project pitching
- Exhibition, publication and editorial coordination
- Artist, gallery, museum and lender liaison

RELEVANT PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Since Jan 2026 | Project Manager for the Director, AWARE at Centre Pompidou (Paris)

- Coordinate research, curatorial, development and partnership projects within AWARE, now integrated into the Centre Pompidou as a research unit dedicated to women artists.
- Conduct and coordinate documentary, bibliographical and visual research; synthesise complex information into research notes, presentations, project documents and public-facing content.
- Act as liaison between AWARE Paris, Centre Pompidou and AWARE-USA, as well as with external institutional and private partners.
- Prospect and develop institutional partnerships in France and internationally; support fundraising and sponsor management, including project presentations, grant applications and reporting.

Jan 2024 - Dec 2025 | Project Manager for the Director, AWARE: Archives of Women Artists, Research and Exhibitions (Paris)

- Supported the Director across research, curatorial, editorial, partnership and development projects, coordinating multiple contributors and deadlines.
- Conceived and coordinated the expansion of AWARE's research platform into women architects and designers, from project development and fundraising through institutional partnerships, contributor coordination, editorial production and online publication.
- Secured €120,000 in sponsorship support in 2024 through prospecting, project development, pitching, grant applications and sponsor reporting.
- Developed partnerships with institutions including V&A London, SMK Copenhagen, Musée Cognac-Jay and Musée du Quai Branly, and coordinated projects with international partners.
- Prepared and delivered presentations on AWARE's projects and curatorial approaches in French and English for institutional and corporate stakeholders.
- Managed two interns and coordinated junior colleagues across specific research and development projects.

Mar - Dec 2023 | Researcher, AWARE (Paris)

- Documentary, bibliographical and image research on modern Japanese women artists for an international exhibition project.
- Conceived, organised and introduced a roundtable at the National Portrait Gallery, London, including coordination with institutional and external participants.

Oct 2021 - Mar 2023 | Research Programmes Assistant, AWARE (Paris)

- Conducted research and supported international partnerships and cultural projects, including Frieze Masters London, Art UK, Villa Albertine, A.I.R. Gallery, Clark Art Institute and National Portrait Gallery London.
- Assisted with coordination of the AWARE Prizes for Women Artists, including artist liaison and public-facing materials.
- Coordinated conferences, round tables and associated documentary research for projects involving Paris Photo, Centre Pompidou, India and Japan.

Jan - Aug 2021 | Curatorial and Research Intern, Royal Scottish Academy of Art and Architecture (Edinburgh)

- Research in the archives and inventory of the Academy's works; transcription and editing of obituaries of former members for the website.
- Specialised in nineteenth- and twentieth-century Scottish art and architecture.

SELECTED CURATORIAL PROJECTS & CULTURAL PROJECTS

2026 | Curator, Donner Corps. Women Artists and Ceramics, Musée Bertrand (Châteauroux)

- Forthcoming exhibition on contemporary ceramics and the body, developed in dialogue with the museum's collection and local ceramics history; artist liaison includes Elsa Sahal, Migline Paroumanou and Myriam Mihindou.

2025 | Co-curator, Trajectoires que je suis, laureates of the AWARE honorary prize, FRAC Champagne-Ardenne (Reims)

- Co-curated with Matylda Taszycka; work included research, checklist development, artist/lender liaison, interpretive texts and coordination with production and registrar teams.

2023 | Co-curator, Modern Women, Frieze Masters (London)

- Co-curated with Camille Morineau and Matylda Taszycka; coordinated galleries and object selections for an international fair context.

2022 | Co-curator, Spotlight, Frieze Masters (London)

- Co-curated with Camille Morineau and Matylda Taszycka; research, gallery liaison and display coordination.

2024 | Research assistant, Women Artists of the American West: Trailblazers at the Turn of the 20th Century, History Jackson Hole (Wyoming, USA)

2022 | Research assistant, Pionnières: Artistes dans le Paris des années folles, Musée du Luxembourg (Paris)

WRITING AND EDITORIAL

2026 | Editor and writer, *Donner Corps. Artistes femmes et céramique*, Éditions de l'Aube

2024 - 2025 | Researcher and writing assistant, *Oser le nu*, Camille Morineau, Flammarion

- Art-historical research, manuscript development, editorial follow-up and proofing on layout.

2024 | Researcher and writing assistant, "In the continuity of community", Manal AlDowayan: Shifting Sands: A Battle Song, Electa

2023 | Author, "Modern Women", Gagosian Quarterly

2022 | Author, "Pioneers: artists in the Paris of the Roaring Twenties", awarewomenartists.com

TEACHING, LECTURES AND PUBLIC SPEAKING

2026 - 2027 | Lecturer, MA module "Gender and Curating", Paris 3 Sorbonne Nouvelle (Paris)

- Designed and teaches the module independently, connecting curatorial practice with gender, feminist and queer theory.

2026-2027 | Lecturer, L2 modules "British Art 1850-today" and "British Art 1900-today", Institut Catholique de Paris

- Independently teaches the module.

2025 - 2026 | Teaching Fellow / Vacataire, M2 Gender Studies, Paris 1 Panthéon-Sorbonne (Paris)

- Taught seminars on equality policies and cultural/institutional frameworks.

2025 | Speaker, Feminist Art History Conference (Washington, DC)

2023 | Guest speaker, American University of Paris (Paris)

Additional public lectures and talks include museum and non-specialist audiences, including a lecture cycle on women artists in the Musée d'Orsay collections.

EDUCATION

MSc History of Art, Theory and Display, First Class, University of Edinburgh, College of Arts (Edinburgh)

- Dissertation: "The Role of the Occult in Gendering the Woman: Women and the Occult in Modern Art", supervised by Michelle Foot.

BA (Hons) and MA English Language and Literature, 2:1, University of Oxford (Oxford)

LANGUAGES AND DIGITAL SKILLS

- Languages: English and French bilingual/native level; extensive professional working experience in both languages.
- Digital and administrative tools: Microsoft Office (Word, Excel, PowerPoint), Google Workspace, collaborative project files, digital archives, image/caption management, online publishing workflows and social media platforms.